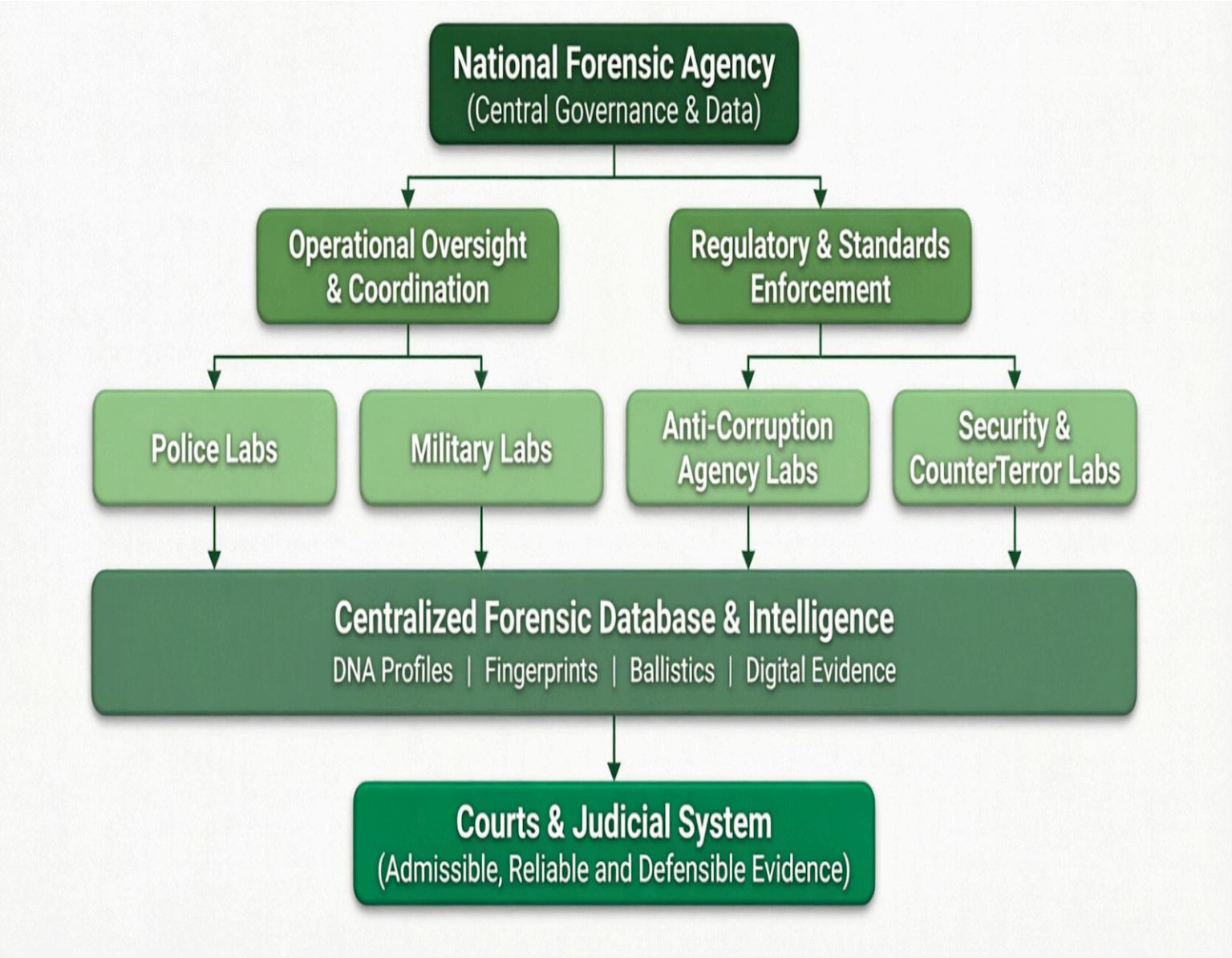
NIGERIA'S NATIONAL FORENSIC AGENCY:

GOVERNANCE, COORDINATION, AND OPERATIONAL BLUEPRINT



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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The National Forensic Agency (NFA) of Nigeria will establish a coordinated forensic system, integrating operational capabilities across existing institutions under centralized governance. The agency will oversee crime laboratories, DNA profiling, digital forensics, and crime scene management while enforcing unified standards, accreditation, and evidence-handling protocols. By eliminating fragmentation and ensuring interoperability, the NFA will deliver forensic evidence that is scientifically reliable, legally defensible, and admissible in court. This framework will strengthen investigations, enhance judicial outcomes, and restore public confidence in Nigeria's criminal justice system.

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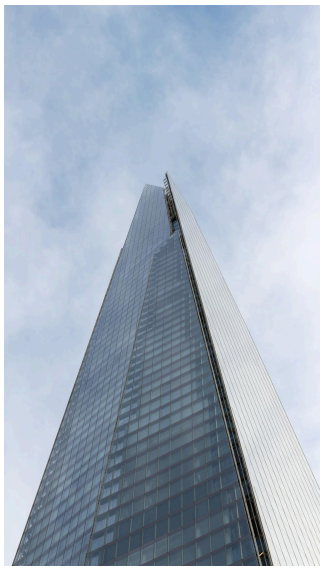

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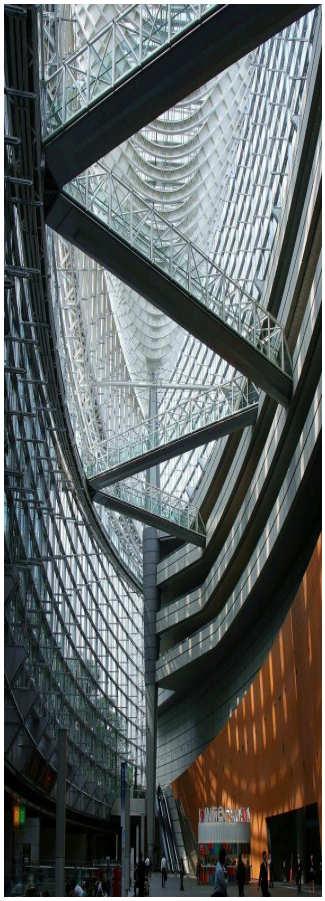

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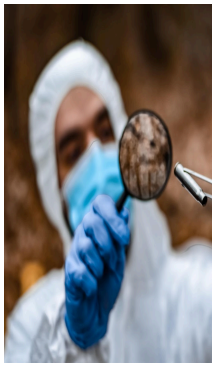
1. INTRODUCTION



Forensic science is a cornerstone of modern criminal justice systems, turning scientific evidence into actionable intelligence that strengthens investigations, supports judicial decisions, and reinforces public trust. Globally, forensic capabilities from DNA profiling to digital forensics have transformed how crimes are solved, suspects are identified, and justice is delivered[1]. In Nigeria, the rise of complex crimes, including cyber-enabled fraud, organized networks, and sophisticated violent offenses, exposes the limitations of current investigative methods. Nigeria possesses institutions handling genomics, bioethics, and forensic analyses; these resources operate in isolation, often producing fragmented outputs that fail to translate into meaningful criminal intelligence. This policy framework argues that Nigeria's challenge is not the absence of scientific expertise, but the lack of a unified, coordinated forensic and genomic integration system capable of delivering reliable, timely, and actionable evidence to law enforcement and the courts. Establishing such a framework is essential for modernizing investigations, improving justice outcomes, and restoring public confidence in the nation's criminal justice system.

2. PROBLEM STATEMENT

Forensic science is a cornerstone of modern criminal justice systems, turning scientific evidence into actionable intelligence that strengthens investigations, supports judicial decisions, and reinforces public trust. Globally, forensic capabilities from DNA profiling to digital forensics have transformed how crimes are solved, suspects are identified, and justice is delivered. In Nigeria, the rise of complex crimes, including cyber-enabled fraud, organized networks, Rape and sophisticated violent offenses, exposes the limitations of current investigative methods. Nigeria possesses institutions handling genomics, bioethics, and forensic analyses; these resources operate in isolation, often producing fragmented outputs that fail to translate into meaningful criminal intelligence[2]. Nigeria's challenge is not the absence of scientific expertise, but the lack of a unified, coordinated forensic and genomic integration system capable of delivering reliable, timely, and actionable evidence to law enforcement and the courts. Establishing such a framework is essential for modernizing investigations, improving justice outcomes, and restoring public confidence in the nation's criminal justice system.

[1] National Academy of Sciences. (2009). Strengthening Forensic Science in the United : A Path Forward. Washington,DC: National Academies Press.

[2] UK House of Commons Science and Technology Committee. (2010–2012). *The Forensic Science Service (HC 855)..*

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3. CURRENT FORENSIC LANDSCAPE IN NIGERIA

Nigeria's forensic services are distributed across a patchwork of agencies and institutions with varying capabilities and mandates. The Nigeria Police Force operates forensic units in Lagos and at its headquarters in Abuja, providing basic forensic analyses and digital resource services as part of criminal investigations[3]. A major development in recent years is the expansion of the National Drug Law Enforcement Agency forensic capacity after operating a single lab in Lagos for over 25 years, it inaugurated state-of-the-art forensic laboratories in Abuja and Enugu in 2025 and upgraded its Lagos facility to enhance drug-related forensic analysis and prosecution efforts. There are also forensic units within other federal bodies, such as the Independent Corrupt Practices and Other Related Offences Commission, whose Computer Security & Forensic Unit has digital forensic equipment and carries out cybercrime and evidentiary analyses, though it functions without standardized national accreditation. In the security services, institutions such as the National Counter-Terrorism Centre (NCTC) maintain multiple forensic capabilities including DNA, toxicology, fingerprint, and digital labs though these facilities remain underdeveloped, dormant, or uncoordinated due to limited resourcing and integration. The military services (e.g., Nigerian Air Force) have commissioned forensic and digital crime laboratories such as the one in Jos to support internal investigations and security operations, but these operate within service-specific structures rather than as part of a unified national forensic system. Collectively, these facilities highlight that Nigeria does have forensic science resources, but lack national standards, accreditation, and data sharing systems.

4. COMPARATIVE GLOBAL ANALYSIS

Effective forensic systems globally are anchored in national coordination, standardized procedures, integrated databases, and robust legal backing, though their governance structures vary by jurisdiction. The prevailing consensus among developed and emerging economies is that forensic integrity requires a statutory framework that mandates accreditation, ensures impartiality, and facilitates data sharing across institutional boundaries[4].

In the United States, forensic laboratories operate at federal, state, and local levels, but interoperability is enforced through federal law. The Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) hosts the Combined DNA Index System (CODIS) and National DNA Index System (NDIS), which link DNA profiles across jurisdictions. Participation by state and local labs in NDIS is not voluntary; it is governed by the DNA Identification Act of 1994, which mandates strict quality standards (ISO 17025) for reliability[5].

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[3] Nigeria Police Force. Organizational Structure and Zonal Commands.

[4] INTERPOL. *Global Forensic and DNA Databasing Guidelines.*

[5] Federal Bureau of Investigation. *Laboratory Services and Forensic Capabilities Overview.*

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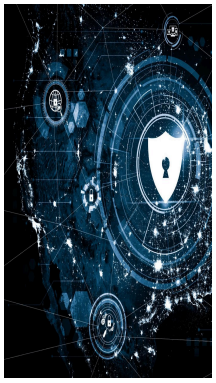

This model demonstrates that distributed operational capabilities can function effectively when bound by a centralized legal and technical authority, a principle central to the proposed NFA framework.

The United Kingdom offers a critical cautionary tale. The collapse of the Forensic Science Service (FSS) in 2011 was attributed to market fragmentation, commoditization of services, and a lack of statutory regulatory power. The UK House of Commons Science and Technology Committee Report (HC 855) highlighted that the Forensic Science Regulator lacked the legal authority to enforce compliance on police laboratories, leading to a two-tier system of quality. The subsequent wind-down of the FSS resulted in loss of intellectual capital and archival risks. For Nigeria, the UK experience underscores the necessity of granting the NFA statutory powers to enforce accreditation across all providers, including security agencies, to prevent the erosion of standards seen in the UK market.

In India, forensic services are coordinated by the Directorate of Forensic Science Services (DFSS) under the Ministry of Home Affairs, which oversees a network of Central Forensic Science Laboratories (CFSLs). Similarly, China has developed national administrative rules requiring accreditation and quality management across hundreds of forensic units. These models illustrate the effectiveness of centralized governance in standardizing forensic practices and improving reliability across a large geography. Russia's forensic landscape, while multi-layered across ministries, still operates under unified federal standards, reinforcing that even distributed systems require a central coordinating authority to ensure evidentiary consistency.

Within Africa, South Africa provides the most relevant legislative precedent for Nigeria through the Criminal Law (Forensic Procedures) Amendment Act, 2013 (Act No. 37 of 2013). This Act legally established the National Forensic DNA Database (NFDD) and introduced mechanisms that align closely with the proposed NFA structure, particularly regarding governance and quality assurance. Section 15V establishes a National Forensic Oversight and Ethics Board, chaired by a retired judge, with representation from forensic experts, human rights lawyers, and public sector officials to monitor implementation, handle complaints, and ensure ethical compliance, thereby separating operational policing from regulatory oversight. Complementing this governance framework, Section 15P mandates compliance with the South African National Accreditation System (SANAS) and ISO standards for all forensic DNA analysis laboratories, ensuring a level playing field between police and external providers. Structurally, the Act defines specific indices for the database under Section 15G, including Crime Scene, Arrestee, Convicted Offender, Investigative, Elimination, and Missing Persons, ensuring data is categorized for legal admissibility and privacy protection.

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Furthermore, Section 15G(2) requires that the analysis of DNA samples and the administration of the database be managed independently, mitigating risks of data manipulation[6]. Across these jurisdictions, national frameworks emphasize uniform standards, accreditation, and data integration to ensure consistency and admissibility of forensic evidence. By contrast, Nigeria's forensic infrastructure, despite having multiple capable institutions, remains structurally fragmented, lacking national coordination, integrated forensic data systems, and a unified legal mandate. This underscores the need for a National Forensic Authority to align the country with global and regional best practices, leveraging the South African legislative model for oversight and accreditation while adopting the US model for centralized coordination of distributed operations.

5. PROPOSED STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK

Nigeria will adopt a centralized forensic authority model anchored on six strategic pillars, explicitly aligned with the general requirements for the competence, impartiality, and consistent operation of laboratories as stipulated in ISO/IEC 17025:2017.

The first pillar is Governance and Independence, also referred to as the Impartiality Protocol. The National Forensic Agency (NFA) shall not fall solely under the Nigeria Police Force or the Ministry of Interior. Instead, it will be established as an independent agency, reporting either to the Ministry of Justice or directly to the National Assembly. This structure ensures impartiality, directly addressing ISO/IEC 17025 Clause 4.1, which mandates that laboratory activities be undertaken impartially and structured to safeguard against commercial, financial, or other pressures[7]. The NFA's Governing Board will comprise representatives from the judiciary, the Nigerian Bar Association, the medical council, academic institutions, and civil society, while operational police command will be excluded from voting on strategic decisions. This governance model is designed to identify and mitigate risks to impartiality arising from relationships, as required by Clause 4.1.4, preserving objectivity and public confidence.

The second pillar is the Funding Model, or the Sustainability Protocol. The NFA's primary funding will come from federal statutory allocation, recognizing forensic science as a cost of justice rather than a policing expense, like the judiciary's budgetary treatment. Secondary funding may include minimal user fees for private civil cases, while all criminal cases remain fully state funded.

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[6] Republic of South Africa. (2013). Criminal Law (Forensic Procedures) Amendment Act, Act No. 37, 2013. Government Gazette, Republic of South Africa

[7] ISO/IEC 17025:2017. General Requirements for the Competence of Testing and Calibration Laboratories. International Organization for Standardization.

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To mitigate volatility, funds will be drawn from the Consolidated Revenue Fund, ensuring stable and predictable financing. This stability supports the management system requirements (Clause 8) necessary to maintain competence and address risks and opportunities without resource-induced compromise.

The third pillar is the Relationship with Security Agencies, known as the Market Protocol. While police and military forces may maintain internal laboratories for rapid screening such as field drug tests or preliminary fingerprint analyses, any evidence intended for prosecution in serious crimes, including homicide, terrorism, economic fraud, and sexual offenses, must be processed or validated by the NFA. Any security agency that seeks to handle court-submittable evidence internally must achieve ISO/IEC 17025 accreditation under the supervision of the NFA. This accreditation will verify personnel competence (Clause 6.2), the validity of methods (Clause 7.2), and the evaluation of measurement uncertainty (Clause 7.6). This mitigates risks of unaccredited or inconsistent forensic practices and ensures the validity of results (Clause 7.7) is maintained across all providers.

The fourth pillar, Operational Architecture, or the Cohesion Protocol, entails establishing six zonal forensic hubs aligned with Nigeria's geopolitical zones North-West, North-East, North-Central, South-West, South-East, and South-South, centrally managed by the National Forensic Agency (NFA). This structure ensures national cohesion and standardization while maintaining strategic proximity to crime scenes across the country, thereby avoiding the fragmentation observed in other jurisdictions. Each hub will adhere to ISO/IEC 17025 Clause 6.3, ensuring facilities and environmental conditions do not adversely affect the validity of results. By consolidating operations into six regional hubs rather than multiple smaller units, the model enhances efficiency, resource optimization, and rapid response capacity. The NFA will also oversee centralized procurement of forensic reagents, equipment, and technology nationwide, leveraging economies of scale to reduce costs, maintain quality, and prevent the commoditization of forensic services, ensuring metrological traceability (Clause 6.5) is maintained across all zones.

The fifth pillar is Research and Development, termed the Innovation Protocol. The NFA will formalize academic partnerships with Nigerian universities such as ABU, UDU, UNIMAID, MAU, UNIABUJA, UNILORIN, UI, OAU, UNN, UNIZIK, UNICAL, and UNIBEN ensuring that forensic research is closely integrated with operational practice. Nigerian universities will host NFA research fellows and a dedicated innovation fund will support the development of forensic technologies tailored to local environmental conditions, including heat-stable DNA kits and tropical decomposition models, fostering homegrown innovation and capacity building. This aligns with the standard requirement for continual improvement (Clause 8.6) and the validation of non-standard methods (Clause 7.2.2).

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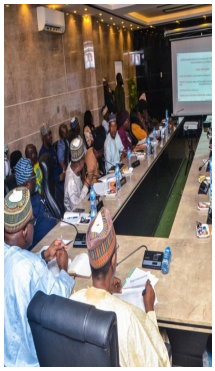
The final pillar is The National Forensic Archive, or the Justice Protocol. The NFA will hold custodial rights over all forensic data, rather than the police, ensuring consistent legal custody and a chain of evidence. A secure, blockchain-enabled system will track evidence digitally from the crime scene to the courtroom, preserving integrity. This system will comply with ISO/IEC 17025 Clause 7.5 (Technical Records), ensuring records contain sufficient information to facilitate the repetition of laboratory activities and identify factors affecting results. Statutory access rights will be granted to the defense and to bodies such as the Criminal Cases Review Commission, if established, preventing information asymmetry and ensuring fairness, a challenge commonly observed in other developing justice systems. Control of these records will adhere to Clause 8.4, ensuring protection, backup, and retrieval. Together, these six pillars create a robust, centralized authority model that balances operational decentralization with strong governance, quality assurance, and integration, positioning Nigeria to leapfrog the structural and institutional challenges experienced by other nations.

6. IMPLEMENTATION STRATEGY



The National Forensic Agency (NFA) of Nigeria will be implemented following a phased approach to ensure legal, institutional, and operational stability. In Phase 1 (Months 1–12), the focus will be on establishing the legislative framework through the drafting and passage of the National Forensic Agency Act, which will define statutory powers, funding mechanisms, and regulatory oversight. A critical provision will be the inclusion of a sunset clause requiring all internal forensic laboratories within security agencies to achieve accreditation within a defined period, such as five years, or cease processing evidence for court purposes. Phase 2 (Months 13–24) will concentrate on consolidation and standardization. This will involve a comprehensive audit of existing forensic capabilities across the Police, Military, and anti-corruption agencies, followed by the gradual transfer of complex forensic casework to NFA zonal laboratories. During this phase, the National Forensic Quality Standard aligned with ISO 17025 but expanded to cover interpretation and reporting will be implemented to ensure uniformity and reliability across all forensic outputs. Phase 3 (Months 25–36) will focus on capacity building and research development[8]. This will include the launch of a national forensic scholarship scheme to train scientists both locally and internationally, the establishment of the National Forensic Archive, and the initiation of structured research and development partnerships with Nigerian universities to drive innovation and sustainability within the forensic system

[8] United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2020). *Model Legislative Provisions on Forensic Science and Criminal Justice.* Vienna: UNODC.

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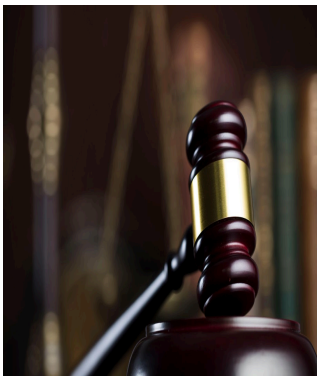
7. LEGISLATIVE AND DATA GOVERNANCE ARCHITECTURE FOR A NATIONAL FORENSIC AGENCY IN NIGERIA

The establishment of a National Forensic Agency in Nigeria requires a dual legislative approach that combines the creation of a new statutory body with targeted amendments to existing legal frameworks to ensure doctrinal coherence and operational effectiveness.

This process begins with the enactment of a comprehensive National Forensic Agency Act, which will formally establish the agency as a statutory body corporate with perpetual succession. This primary legislation must clearly define the agency's powers regarding forensic accreditation, standardization, data banking, and inter-agency coordination, thereby creating a unified regulatory framework that currently does not exist. However, the creation of this institution alone is insufficient without complementing it by refining the Evidence Act 2011 and the Nigeria Data Protection Act 2023 to accommodate the unique demands of modern forensic governance and data handling.



Reforms to the Evidence Act 2011 are critical to align evidentiary rules with contemporary forensic practices and to secure the admissibility of scientific evidence in Nigerian courts. Section 67, which currently restricts the admissibility of opinion evidence, must be expanded to explicitly recognize forensic methodologies and experts certified by the National Forensic Agency, ensuring that scientifically validated opinions are treated with the requisite legal weight. Furthermore, Section 14, which grants judicial discretion to exclude improperly obtained evidence, necessitates the incorporation of nationally standardized chain-of-custody protocols under the authority of the new agency to guarantee consistency in evidentiary handling and prevent the exclusion of crucial forensic data due to procedural ambiguities. Section 3 offers a strategic opportunity to anchor the National Forensic Agency Act as the governing framework for forensic admissibility, while Section 255 subsections 1 and 2 require adjustment to delegate forensic regulatory authority from the Minister to the specialized and independent institution, thus removing political interference from technical oversight. Although the Evidence Act provides a general foundation for admissibility, it currently lacks the institutional and procedural specificity required for the scientific validation of forensic evidence, a gap that these amendments aim to close[9].

Parallel to evidentiary reforms, the Nigeria Data Protection Act 2023 must be refined to address the specific complexities of forensic data governance, particularly regarding sensitive genetic and biometric information.

[9] Evidence Act, 2011 (Laws of the Federation of Nigeria).

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While Section 4 subsections 1 and 2 provide a legislative template for establishing statutory bodies, they require expansion to reflect the specialized mandate of a forensic agency, specifically including provisions for evidence management and inter-agency data integration essential for criminal investigations. Section 30, which governs the processing of sensitive personal data, must be amended to expressly recognize the National Forensic Agency as a lawful data processor for criminal justice purposes, supported by clear exemptions under Section 3 subsection 2 for law enforcement activities to prevent legal bottlenecks during active investigations.

Additionally, Section 44 should be extended to mandate the registration of all forensic laboratories and service providers with the National Forensic Agency, creating a unified regulatory perimeter, while Section 65 requires the inclusion of forensic-specific definitions such as forensic data, biometric evidence, and chain of custody to eliminate ambiguity in interpretation and application. Although Sections 24 and 25 on lawful processing and Sections 39 and 40 on data security provide a strong normative foundation, the Act currently lacks the institutional mechanisms necessary for forensic standardization and oversight, which these targeted amendments will provide[10].

The synergy between the new National Forensic Agency Act and the amended Evidence and Data Protection Acts is essential to ensure the integrity, admissibility, and interoperability of forensic evidence in Nigeria. Without such coordinated reforms, the forensic landscape will remain fragmented and legally vulnerable, failing to meet international best practices in forensic governance. The proposed legislative architecture ensures that the new agency operates with clear statutory backing, that its outputs are automatically admissible in court through updated evidentiary rules, and that its handling of sensitive biological data complies with robust privacy standards tailored for law enforcement. This holistic legal overhaul transforms the forensic system from a collection of isolated capabilities into a cohesive, nationally coordinated infrastructure capable of delivering reliable and timely justice.

8. EXPECTED IMPACT

The National Forensic Authority (NFA) of Nigeria will deliver immediate and systemic improvements across Nigeria's security and justice architecture. It will enable faster suspect identification, case linkage across jurisdictions, and reduced investigation timelines through integrated DNA, fingerprint, ballistics, and digital databases.

[10] Nigeria Data Protection Act, 2023.

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It will strengthen the judiciary by ensuring consistent, admissible, and scientifically validated evidence, leading to higher conviction accuracy, fewer wrongful prosecutions, and reduced case backlogs[11]. At the security level, it will enhance counterterrorism, intelligence gathering, and tracking of organized crime networks, while enabling effective disaster victim identification and missing persons resolution. Institutionally, it will eliminate duplication, improve inter-agency collaboration, and drive standardization, accreditation, and professionalization of forensic practice nationwide. At a deeper level, it will establish Nigeria's capacity for forensic genomics, biosecurity surveillance, and digital intelligence, positioning the country to respond to emerging threats including cybercrime and biological risks.

10. CHALLENGES AND RISK MITIGATION

The establishment of a National Forensic Authority (NFA) entails navigating complex systemic and operational risks that require proactive strategic mitigation. Primary among these is potential political and institutional resistance from existing security agencies, such as the Police and Military, who may perceive the NFA's centralized oversight as an encroachment on their operational autonomy; this necessitates robust legislative backing through the NFA Act that clearly delineates regulatory authority from operational execution to assuage sovereignty concerns. Financial sustainability poses another critical challenge, as reliance on sporadic budgetary approvals could stall laboratory development and database integration; consequently, funding must be statutorily charged to the Consolidated Revenue Fund, supplemented by diversified financing mechanisms including grants and regulated public-private partnerships to ensure continuity. Institutional rivalry and fragmentation, historically evident in the Nigerian forensic landscape, will be countered by the NFA's hybrid governance model which mandates standardized protocols and inter-agency memoranda of understanding to enforce cohesion without dissolving existing operational units. Furthermore, the handling of sensitive forensic data introduces significant privacy and security risks that must be addressed through strict alignment with the Nigeria Data Protection Act 2023, requiring formal amendments to empower the NFA while ensuring oversight by the Nigeria Data Protection Commission (NDPC) to prevent misuse[12]. Technical capacity gaps and infrastructure deficits will be managed through a phased rollout strategy that prioritizes regional hubs and continuous professional development via international collaborations. By embedding these mitigation strategies into the foundational legal and operational framework, the NFA can secure operational integrity, foster inter-agency trust, and achieve its strategic mandate of delivering reliable, admissible forensic evidence within the Nigerian criminal justice system[13].

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[11] National Institute of Justice. *Forensic Science Standards and Practices.*

[12] Forensic Science Regulator. *Annual Reports and Codes of Practice.*

[13] U.S. Commission on the Roles and Capabilities of the United States Intelligence *Preparing for the 21st Century: An Appraisal of US Intelligence.*

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11. CONCLUSION AND POLICY RECOMMENDATIONS

The establishment of a National Forensic Agency (NFA) represents an urgent strategic imperative for Nigeria. The current fragmentation of forensic capabilities across disparate agencies has critically undermined the efficacy of criminal investigations, compromised the accuracy of judicial outcomes, and eroded the integrity of national security systems. This structural disarray has resulted in inconsistent evidence of handling, significant analytical delays, and vulnerabilities regarding the admissibility of scientific evidence in court.

A centralized NFA would rectify these deficiencies by consolidating technical expertise, enforcing standardized procedures, and developing integrated national databases for DNA, fingerprints, ballistics, and digital forensics. Such an institutional framework would not only enhance coordination among law enforcement and intelligence bodies but also significantly strengthen the reliability and efficiency of the broader criminal justice system.

Nigeria possesses a distinct structural advantage in implementing this model. Unlike jurisdictions such as the United Kingdom, where attempts to commercialize forensic science were hindered by a fragmented policing structure and market instability, Nigeria operates under a more centralized policing system. To fully leverage this advantage, the proposed framework must be anchored on four pillars: statutory funding, regulatory independence, centralized archival custody, and a clear institutional separation between investigative functions and scientific analysis. Under this model, the Nigeria Police Force and other security agencies would retain responsibility for investigations, while the NFA would assume exclusive authority over forensic analysis, accreditation, and standard setting. This separation is fundamental to ensuring objectivity, scientific integrity, and public trust.

Furthermore, the necessity of this reform is underscored by global precedents. As highlighted in the landmark 2009 report by the National Academy of Sciences (NAS) in the United States, titled Strengthening Forensic Science in the United States: A Path Forward, the absence of a unified national standards body and independent oversight leads to systemic flaws, including unreliable methodologies and a lack of rigorous research. The NAS report explicitly called for the creation of a strong, independent federal entity to set standards, conduct research, and oversee the application of forensic sciences recommendations that directly align with the proposed mandate of the Nigerian NFA. By heeding these international lessons, Nigeria can avoid the structural pitfalls observed in other jurisdictions.

Accordingly, it is recommended that a Presidential Implementation Committee be constituted without delay in drafting a comprehensive National Forensic Agency Bill. This committee should be mandated to design the legal, institutional, and operational frameworks necessary to establish a robust, independent, and nationally coordinated forensic system.

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[6] Federal Bureau of Investigation. Laboratory Services and Forensic Capabilities Overview.

[7] National Institute of Justice. Forensic Science Standards and Practices.

[8] INTERPOL. Global Forensic and DNA Databasing Guidelines.

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